

# CVE-2026-31431 — Copy Fail

Linux Kernel Local Privilege Escalation • Disclosed 2026-04-29 • CVSS 7.8 HIGH • All major distros affected

**9 yr**

Exposure window (2017–2026)

**732 B**

Exploit size (Python)

**<1 sec**

Time to root

**0**

Forensic artifacts left

## WHY THIS IS NOT A NORMAL CVE

No race condition. No KASLR bypass. No kernel address leak. Deterministic, 100% reliable, runs as any unprivileged user, leaves no trace on disk or in audit logs. Same class as Dirty Pipe (CVE-2022-0847) but with better operational security built into the physics of the bug.

## What's Broken

Three kernel components that were never designed to interact:

| Component                                          | Shipped                                         | Purpose                                                          |
|----------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <code>authencesn</code> algorithm                  | 2011                                            | IPsec ESP extended sequence number authentication                |
| <code>AF_ALG</code> AEAD socket support            | 2015                                            | Exposes kernel crypto operations to unprivileged userspace       |
| In-place optimization in <code>algif_aead.c</code> | <b>2017</b> (commit <code>72548b093ee3</code> ) | Performance optimization merging source/destination scatterlists |

The 2017 optimization set `req->src = req->dst` , meaning AEAD operations read and write to the same memory buffers. The `authencesn` algorithm writes 4 scratch bytes at a controlled offset as internal working space. When a user `splice()` s a file’s page-cache pages into the crypto pipeline, those scratch bytes land **directly in the page cache of the target file** – bypassing all file permission checks.

## Attack Chain

- 1 Open an `AF_ALG` socket and bind to `authencesn(hmac(sha256),cbc(aes))` . No privileges required.
- 2 `splice()` a target file’s page-cache pages into the crypto socket via a pipe. The kernel maps the actual page-cache pages by reference, not by copy.
- 3 Controlled 4 bytes are placed in the AAD (Associated Authenticated Data) as `seqno_lo` . The `authencesn` algorithm writes these 4 bytes into the destination scatterlist at a calculated offset – which is the file’s page cache.
- 4 The HMAC check fails (garbage ciphertext), `recv()` returns an error – but the scratch write has already landed. Iterate to build up arbitrary page-cache modifications 4 bytes at a time.
- 5 Execute the corrupted binary or leverage the corrupted data. Root achieved.

## TWO KNOWN EXPLOITATION STRATEGIES

**Binary corruption:** Write compressed shellcode into the page-cached copy of `/usr/bin/su`, then execute it.

**UID patching:** Overwrite the running user's UID field in the page-cached `/etc/passwd` from `1000` to `0000`, then `su <user>` with your own password drops a root shell.

## Why There Is No Forensic Trail

- **Page cache is volatile memory.** The corruption lives in RAM, not on disk. No file modification timestamp, no journal entry, no `fsck` evidence.
- **The kernel never marks the page dirty.** The write came through the crypto subsystem, not the filesystem write path – so it is never written back to disk.
- **Reboot destroys all evidence.** Cold boot = clean state. Memory pressure evicts the page silently.
- **auditd doesn't see it.** There is no `write()` or `open(..., O_WRONLY)` syscall to log.
- **File integrity tools see a clean file.** AIDE, Tripwire, `rpm -Va` all compare against disk.
- **inotify / fanotify don't fire.** The file was never "modified" from the VFS perspective.

**Only real-time detection works:** Falco or Sysdig watching for `socket(AF_ALG, SOCK_SEQPACKET) + bind("aead", "authencsn(...))`. After the fact, there is nothing to find.

## Affected Systems

Every Linux kernel built with `CONFIG_CRYPTO_USER_API_AEAD` from kernel 4.14 (late 2017) **or later**, up to the patched versions.

| Distribution                  | Status      | Notes                                                                                  |
|-------------------------------|-------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Red Hat Enterprise Linux 10.1 | CONFIRMED   | Kernel 6.12.0 – <code>algif_aead</code> compiled in ( <code>=y</code> ), cannot unload |
| Red Hat Enterprise Linux 9.x  | AFFECTED    | Kernel 5.14+ – in vulnerable range                                                     |
| Red Hat Enterprise Linux 8.x  | AFFECTED    | Kernel 4.18 – in vulnerable range                                                      |
| Ubuntu 24.04 LTS              | CONFIRMED   | Exploit verified by researchers                                                        |
| Amazon Linux 2023             | CONFIRMED   | Kernel 6.18                                                                            |
| SUSE 16                       | CONFIRMED   | Kernel 6.12                                                                            |
| Alpine Linux (containers)     | AFFECTED    | <code>algif_aead</code> shipped as module by default                                   |
| NVIDIA L4T (Jetson)           | AFFECTED    | Ubuntu-based kernel, JetPack 5.x/6.x – see edge section below                          |
| OpenWrt / DD-WRT              | LIKELY SAFE | Stripped kernels usually disable <code>AF_ALG</code> userspace API                     |
| Fedora (current)              | PATCHED     | Kernel $\geq$ 6.19.12                                                                  |

## CVSS & Tracking

| Field               | Value                                                                         |
|---------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| CVE                 | CVE-2026-31431                                                                |
| CVSS 3.1            | 7.8 HIGH                                                                      |
| Attack Vector       | Local                                                                         |
| Attack Complexity   | Low                                                                           |
| Privileges Required | Low (any unprivileged user)                                                   |
| User Interaction    | None                                                                          |
| Red Hat Bugzilla    | Bug 2460538 – Status: NEW, Severity: High                                     |
| Upstream Fix        | Commit <code>a664bf3d603d</code> (Herbert Xu) – kernels 7.0, 6.19.12, 6.18.22 |
| Introduced          | Commit <code>72548b093ee3</code> – kernel 4.14 (2017)                         |
| Disclosed           | 2026-04-29                                                                    |
| Discovered By       | Theori / Xint Code (AI-powered security research) – found in ~1 hour          |

## Immediate Mitigation

If `algif_aead` is a loadable module

```
# Blacklist the vulnerable module
echo "install algif_aead /bin/false" > /etc/modprobe.d/disable-algif-aead.conf
rmmod algif_aead 2>/dev/null

# Rebuild initramfs
dracut -f           # RHEL / Fedora
update-initramfs -u # Ubuntu / Debian
```

## If `algif_aead` is compiled in ( `=y` )

Module blacklisting **does not work**. The only mitigations are:

- **Kernel patch** – update to a fixed kernel version
- **SELinux custom policy** – RHEL's default targeted policy allows `alg_socket` creation, but a single custom module can deny it system-wide. AppArmor can deny `AF_ALG` per-profile ( `deny network alg,`  ) but requires updating each profile individually. See mitigation section below.
- **seccomp** – block `socket(AF_ALG, ...)` in container runtimes

### WHAT THE MODULE BLACKLIST DOES NOT BREAK

dm-crypt / LUKS, kTLS, IPsec / XFRM, OpenSSL, GnuTLS, NSS, SSH. These all use kernel crypto directly without the `AF_ALG` userspace socket interface.

### RHEL 10.1 NOTE

On RHEL 10.1 (kernel 6.12.0-124.x), `algif_aead` is compiled into the kernel ( `CONFIG_CRYPTO_USER_API_AEAD=y` ). It cannot be unloaded or blacklisted. You must wait for the kernel errata or deploy SELinux/seccomp mitigations. Red Hat Bugzilla 2460538 is still in NEW status as of 2026-04-30.

## Risk by Environment

| Environment                                     | Risk     | Impact                                                          |
|-------------------------------------------------|----------|-----------------------------------------------------------------|
| Multi-tenant servers (shared shell, dev boxes)  | CRITICAL | Any tenant gets root, compromises all tenants                   |
| Kubernetes / container platforms                | CRITICAL | Container escape via shared page cache; node-level root         |
| CI/CD runners (GitHub Actions, GitLab, Jenkins) | CRITICAL | Untrusted pipeline code gets host root                          |
| AI/ML inference endpoints                       | CRITICAL | Model-serving containers escape to host                         |
| Edge / IoT devices (Jetson, industrial)         | CRITICAL | LPE + no monitoring + slow patch cycles = persistent compromise |
| Single-tenant production servers                | HIGH     | LPE chaining vector after initial foothold                      |
| Single-user workstations                        | MODERATE | Privilege escalation after initial compromise                   |

## Copy Fail at the Edge: NVIDIA Jetson, Ubuntu, and the OT Attack Surface

The “local only” attack vector in the CVSS score masks the real-world risk at the operational technology (OT) edge. Edge devices running mainstream Linux kernels are fully exposed – and they operate in environments where the standard mitigations do not exist.

### NVIDIA Jetson Is Vulnerable

NVIDIA Jetson platforms (Xavier, Orin) run **L4T (Linux for Tegra)** – a full Ubuntu kernel with NVIDIA GPU and DLA drivers. The kernel is not stripped down.

| JetPack Version             | Kernel     | Base OS      | Status                                 |
|-----------------------------|------------|--------------|----------------------------------------|
| JetPack 6.x (Orin)          | 5.15 / 6.1 | Ubuntu 22.04 | <b>VULNERABLE</b>                      |
| JetPack 5.x (Xavier / Orin) | 5.10       | Ubuntu 20.04 | <b>VULNERABLE</b>                      |
| JetPack 4.x (Nano / TX2)    | 4.9        | Ubuntu 18.04 | <b>BELOW RANGE</b> (kernel 4.9 < 4.14) |

`CONFIG_CRYPTO_USER_API_AEAD` is enabled in L4T’s default kernel config. NVIDIA needs the crypto subsystem for dm-crypt, container runtime support, and the network stack. The attack surface is present.



## Why Edge Devices Are Worse Than Servers

### THE COMPOUNDING FACTORS AT THE EDGE

- **Patch lag is measured in months, not days.** NVIDIA controls the L4T kernel. Customers cannot `dnf update` – they must wait for NVIDIA to ship a patched JetPack BSP, then requalify it against their workloads, then roll it to potentially hundreds of field devices.
- **No runtime security monitoring.** Nobody is running Falco, Sysdig, or RHACS on a Jetson in a signal bungalow or a wayside cabinet. The only detection method for Copy Fail (watching for `AF_ALG` socket creation) does not exist at the edge.
- **Ubuntu ships AppArmor, not SELinux.** AppArmor can deny `AF_ALG` via `deny network alg,` rules, but each application profile must be updated individually. SELinux deploys a single module system-wide – a significant operational advantage when hardening hundreds of edge devices.
- **“Local” access is more achievable than it sounds.** Exposed SSH, vulnerable inference APIs, compromised containers, physical access to field-deployed hardware – any foothold becomes root in under a second.
- **Containerized inference is the NVIDIA-recommended pattern.** DeepStream, Triton, and custom models typically run in containers on Jetson. Copy Fail jumps from container to host via the shared page cache. Container isolation is meaningless.

## What These Devices Are Doing

NVIDIA Jetson is deployed across critical infrastructure for edge AI inference:

| Industry              | Edge AI Use Cases                                                                   | Consequence of Root Compromise                                              |
|-----------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Rail / Transportation | Track defect detection, wayside monitoring, container ID scanning, PTC edge compute | Safety system manipulation, signal interference, surveillance of operations |
| Utilities / Energy    | Substation monitoring, predictive maintenance, grid edge analytics                  | SCADA/ICS lateral movement, grid visibility disruption                      |
| Manufacturing         | Quality inspection, robotic guidance, process control                               | Production sabotage, IP exfiltration, safety system bypass                  |
| Healthcare            | Medical imaging inference, patient monitoring, pharmacy automation                  | HIPAA breach, patient safety risk, operational disruption                   |
| Retail / Food         | Refrigeration monitoring, loss prevention, self-checkout AI                         | PCI DSS scope, food safety monitoring gaps                                  |

## The IT/OT Convergence Problem

Edge AI devices are the convergence point between IT and OT networks. A Jetson running computer vision on the OT side is also pulling model updates, reporting telemetry, and running containers – all of which require IP connectivity that creates attack surface. Copy Fail turns any foothold on these devices into root with no forensic evidence.

This is not a hypothetical chain. The components are:

1. Exposed service or container vulnerability on the Jetson → unprivileged shell
2. Copy Fail → root in <1 second, zero artifacts
3. Root on an OT-connected device → lateral movement into industrial control systems
4. No runtime detection at the edge → persistence until hardware replacement

## The Red Hat Counter-Position

| Exposure            | Ubuntu on Jetson (Current State)                                            | Red Hat Device Edge on Jetson                                               |
|---------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Kernel patching     | Wait for NVIDIA JetPack BSP release                                         | Red Hat kernel errata on Red Hat's cadence, independent of NVIDIA           |
| Update mechanism    | <code>apt upgrade</code> – mutable filesystem, no rollback                  | <code>bootc</code> image-based updates – atomic, rollback-capable           |
| MAC enforcement     | AppArmor – per-profile <code>deny network alg,</code> (no system-wide deny) | SELinux – single custom module denies <code>AF_ALG</code> system-wide       |
| Runtime detection   | None (no Falco, no Sysdig)                                                  | Red Hat Advanced Cluster Security (RHACS) with seccomp + Falco integration  |
| Container isolation | Docker – no seccomp filter for <code>AF_ALG</code>                          | Podman + custom seccomp policy blocking <code>AF_ALG</code> socket creation |
| Compliance posture  | No FIPS, no CC evaluation                                                   | FIPS 140-3 validated crypto modules, STIG content, CC certification         |

### SELINUX: THE MECHANISM EXISTS, BUT REQUIRES CUSTOM POLICY

RHEL's default targeted policy **allows** `alg_socket` creation from all confined domains ( `user_t` , `container_t` , `staff_t` ). The exploit works under default SELinux enforcing. However, SELinux provides the **mechanism** to block it: a single custom policy module denying `alg_socket { create }` applies system-wide to all confined domains in one operation. AppArmor can also deny `AF_ALG` sockets via `deny network alg,` rules, but each application profile must be updated individually – there is no system-wide equivalent. At fleet scale, the operational difference matters: one `semodule -i` vs. editing every profile on every host.

## Custom SELinux module to block Copy Fail

```
# copyfail_deny.te
module copyfail_deny 1.0;
require { type user_t; type staff_t; type container_t; class alg_socket create; }
neverallow user_t    self:alg_socket create;
neverallow staff_t    self:alg_socket create;
neverallow container_t self:alg_socket create;
```

```
# Build and install:
checkmodule -M -m -o copyfail_deny.mod copyfail_deny.te
semodule_package -o copyfail_deny.pp -m copyfail_deny.mod
semodule -i copyfail_deny.pp
```

## Talking Points

- **“Local only” on a CVSS score does not mean “safe at the edge.”** Any exposed service, any container escape, any physical access to field hardware satisfies the local vector requirement.
- **You cannot patch what you do not control.** When the OS kernel comes from the hardware vendor (NVIDIA L4T), your security posture is gated by their release schedule. Red Hat Device Edge decouples the kernel from the hardware vendor.
- **Container isolation is not a security boundary for this class of vulnerability.** The page cache is host-wide. Containerized workloads on Jetson share the page cache with the host. Namespace isolation provides zero protection.
- **Red Hat OpenShift at the edge closes this class of vulnerability.** SELinux, seccomp, RHACS, and `bootc` image-based updates provide defense in depth that the current Ubuntu-on-Jetson stack cannot match.
- **Nine years of exposure with zero detection capability.** How many edge devices were compromised via this or similar page-cache attacks? Nobody knows, because nobody was watching, and the exploit leaves no trace.

